



Dak Guru

A Self Learning Portal

www.dakguru.com

Instructions on Maintenance of Annual Performance Assessment Report (APAR)

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

Instructions on Maintenance of Annual Performance Assessment Report (APAR)

1. Fundamental Objectives

The immediate superior officer of a government servant, acting as the Reporting Officer, must write the Annual Performance Assessment Report (APAR) of their subordinates in an **objective and impartial manner**.

The system of APAR has two principal objectives:

1. To improve the performance of the subordinate in their present job.
2. To assess the potentialities of the subordinate and prepare them for future opportunities in service.

The ultimate goal is to optimize the achievement of Government policies and programs. Consequently, the main focus of the Reporting Officer should be **developmental rather than judgmental**. The APAR should serve as a true indicator of the government servant's achievement and not merely as a tool for control or discipline.

2. General Principles and Structure

The performance of every Government servant is assessed annually (**April–March**). This document provides vital inputs for assessing suitability for career advancements such as **confirmation, promotion, deputation, and foreign assignment**.

Structure of the APAR: The APAR is divided into four sections:

- **Section-I (Basic Information):** Filled by the **Administration Division/Personnel Dept.**
- **Section-II (Self-appraisal):** Filled by the **Appraisee**.
- **Section-III (Appraisal):** Filled by the **Reporting Officer** (and Reviewing Officer, if necessary).
- **Section-IV (Review):** Filled by the **Reviewing Officer**.

3. Initiation and Self-Appraisal

The APAR is initiated by the Government servant reported upon (the Appraisee).

- **Duty Description:** The Appraisee must provide a brief description of duties, not exceeding 100 words.
- **Performance Metrics:** The Appraisee specifies targets set, achievements against each target, shortfalls (if any), constraints encountered, and areas of greater achievement.

4. Eligibility and Timelines for Reporting/Reviewing

Minimum Experience Requirement: Officers at both Reporting and Reviewing levels must have at least **3 months** of experience supervising the work and conduct of the Government servant before they can record their assessment.

Specific Scenarios for Reporting:

- **Multiple Reports:** If necessary, two or more independent reports may be written in a year by different Reporting Officers, provided each has at least **3 months** of experience.
- **Absence of Eligible Reporting Officer:** If no Reporting Officer has the requisite experience, the **Reviewing Officer** may initiate the report as a Reporting Officer, provided they have been the same for the entire period and can fill the necessary columns.
- **Retirement:** A Reporting/Reviewing Officer may write the report on subordinates within **one month** of retirement.
- **Suspension:** If under suspension when the APAR is due, the officer may write/review it within **two months** of being placed under suspension or within **one month** from the due date, whichever is later.
- **Transfer:** A Reporting Officer transferred during the year should write APARs for all staff under their control up to the date of transfer within **3–5 weeks** of the transfer.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Calculation of the **3-month** period explicitly excludes leave. If an officer has taken **Earned Leave** for a period of more than **15 days**, the total period spent on leave is deducted from the total period spent on the post. Leave taken for short-term duration is not treated as relevant.

5. Contents and Grading System

Grading Methodology: Numerical grading is awarded on a scale of **1–10** for the quality of work output, personal attributes, and functional competence.

- **1** refers to the lowest grade.
- **10** refers to the highest grade.

Weightage for Overall Grade: The overall grade (Score 1–10) is calculated based on :

- **40%** weightage on **Assessment of Work Output**.
- **30%** weightage on **Assessment of Personal Attributes**.
- **30%** weightage on **Functional Competency**.

Grading Definitions: The grading scale is defined as follows:

Grading Score	Average Score for Promotion	Rating Description
Between 8 and 10	9	Outstanding
Between 6 and less than 8	7	Very Good
Between 4 and less than 6	5	Good
Below 4	0	(Unrated)

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE (2025 Context):** Under the 7th CPC guidelines (MACP and Promotion), the benchmark for financial upgradation and promotion has been enhanced to **"Very Good"** (Grading score of **6 and above**). The "Good" benchmark (Score 5) is no longer sufficient for MACP/Promotion effects.

6. Integrity and Justification Guidelines

Integrity Column: The Reporting Officer must select one of the following three options regarding integrity :

1. "Beyond doubt"
2. "Since the integrity of the officer is doubtful, a secret note is attached."
3. "Not watched the officer's work for sufficient time to form a definite judgment but nothing adverse has been reported to me about the officer."

General Guidelines for Filling APAR:

- **Absence & Training:** The period of absence (leave, training, etc.) must be mentioned. Details of training attended and the date of filing property returns must be recorded.
- **Justification of Extremes:** Any grading of **1 or 2** (low) must be adequately justified with specific failures. Similarly, any grade of **9 or 10** (high) must be justified with specific accomplishments.
- **Peer Comparison:** Authorities should rate the officer against a larger population of peers currently or previously working under them.

Timely Completion of APAR

1. Handling Gaps in Reporting

Wherever there is any gap in the APAR during a particular reporting period, it is the responsibility of the officer in-charge of maintaining the APAR to place a **"No Report Certificate"** in the dossier indicating the specific reasons. Valid reasons include:

- The officer has not worked for a minimum of **3 months** under a reporting officer.
- The officer was on **leave/training** during the period.
- The officer was on **unauthorized absence** (if factually established).
- The APAR could not be completed due to the lapse of the time limit for making remarks by the retired Reporting/Reviewing Officer.

2. Specific Scenarios

- **Honorary/Part-time Officials:** Annual Performance Assessment Reports need not be written for officers appointed on an honorary or purely part-time basis.
- **Deputation/Foreign Service:**
 - In the case of Central Government servants deputed to other Departments, State Governments, or on Foreign Service, the APAR should be maintained by their **parent Departments**.
 - The periodicity of such confidential reports should generally be the same as in the parent Department.
 - It is the responsibility of the **parent Department** to obtain the reports of their officers on deputation and maintain them.

Miscellaneous Matters

1. Custody of APARs

The maintenance and custody of the Annual Performance Assessment Reports are regulated as follows:

- **Group 'A' and Group 'B':** Kept by the **Head of the Department** or any other authority specified by them.

- **Group 'C':** Kept by the authority specified by the **Head of the Department**.
- **Constraint:** The APAR should **not** in any case be kept by an authority higher than the appointing authority.

2. Handling Dossiers for Selection

Whenever it becomes necessary to send the APAR dossier to an outside authority for purposes such as selection, promotion, or appointment:

- It is advisable to retain the **original APAR dossier** with the cadre authorities and send only a **photocopy**.
- Care must be taken to ensure that the photocopies are **destroyed immediately** after the purpose for which they were made has been accomplished.

3. Preservation Period

The APARs must be preserved for the following durations:

- **In case of Death:** Preserved for **2 years** from the date of death.
- **Retirement / Dismissal / Removal / Resignation:** Preserved for **5 years** from the date of the event.

Appeals, Benchmarks, and Online Systems

1. Appeals and Relations

- **Appeal Timeline:** An appeal against the rejection of a representation for an adverse remark must be made within **6 months**.
- **Near Relatives:** As far as possible, a near relative should not be posted under a Reporting Authority for a long period. If inescapable, the APAR should be written by the **Reviewing Officer**.

2. Performance Benchmarks (7th CPC Context)

- **For DPC (Promotion):** Minimum "**Very Good**" benchmark is required in **3 years** out of the last **5 years**.
- **For MACP:** Minimum "**Very Good**" benchmark is required in **5 years** out of the last **5 years**.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Under the **7th Pay Commission** (effective 2016 and continuing through 2025), the benchmark for all financial upgradations (MACP) and most regular promotions was

enhanced from "Good" to "**Very Good**". Any grading below 6 (Numerical Grade) renders an employee unfit for MACP.

3. SPARROW System

SPARROW (Smart Performance Appraisal Report Recording Online Window) is an online system for performance appraisal of officers, maintained by the National Informatics Centre (NIC).

- **Scope:** In the Department of Posts, all APARs pertaining to **Group 'A'** officers (SSP Cadre onwards) are processed in SPARROW.
- **Launch:** The system was launched on **01/04/2014**.

Key Administrative Guidelines (Department of Posts)

The following roles are prescribed for specific cadres within the Department of Posts:

Cadre	Reporting Officer	Reviewing Officer
IP / ASP	SSP / SP	DPS
PS Group B	DPS	PMG or CPMG
PA / LSG / HSG	SSP / SP of the Division	(As per Circle norms)
MTS / Postman / MG	Inspector of Posts / Postmaster / HRO	(As per Circle norms)

Additional Notes:

- **MTS APAR:** MTS APARs are written as **Group C** employees effectively from **01.04.2019**.
- **Custodians:**
 - **DPS (HQ):** Custodian of APARs for **IP/ASP** officers.
 - **Sr. Private Secretary to CPMG:** Custodian for **PS Group B** officers of the entire Circle.
- **Self-Appraisal:** Submission of self-appraisal is mandatory for officials in the cadre of **LSG and above**.

Annexure: Time Schedule for APAR*(Reporting Year = Financial Year)*

S. No.	Activity	Deadline
1.	Distribution of blank APAR forms to all concerned (i.e., to the officer to be reported upon where self-appraisal is required).	31st March (May be completed a week earlier)
2.	Submission of self-appraisal to the Reporting Officer by the officer to be reported upon (where applicable).	15th April
3.	Submission of report by Reporting Officer to the Reviewing Officer.	30th June
4.	Completion of Report by Reviewing Officer and sending to Administration/CR Section/Cell.	31st July
5.	Appraisal by Accepting Authority , wherever provided.	31st August
6.	Disclosure to the officer reported upon: (a) Where there is no Accepting Authority. (b) Where there is an Accepting Authority.	1st September 15th September
7.	Receipt of representation , if any, on APAR.	15 days from date of receipt of communication
8.	Forwarding of representations to the Competent Authority: (a) Where there is no Accepting Authority. (b) Where there is an Accepting Authority.	21st September 6th October
9.	Disposal of representation by the Competent Authority.	Within one month from receipt of representation
10.	Communication of the decision of the Competent Authority on the representation by the APAR Cell.	15th November
11.	End of entire APAR process (Final taking on record).	30th November